

# Overcoming Loneliness

For Black women — building bonds where you're seen, whole

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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## BEFORE YOU BEGIN

# Your loneliness isn't a flaw

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For many Black women, loneliness has a particular flavour: being 'the only one' in certain spaces, lacking places where you feel truly understood and safe, wearing the mask of 'the strong woman' who needs no one. That is not a flaw in you — it is largely a system that never made room for you.

This guide validates what you live and helps you out of loneliness in two moves: reconnect with yourself, then build bonds where you're seen, whole. With concrete tips.

### Your intention

In one sentence, what bond would you like to create or rebuild? \_\_\_\_\_

## The 4 approaches

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This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

**Psychodynamic** — understand the root.

**CBT** — ease the negative thoughts.

**Humanistic** — reconcile with yourself.

**Systemic** — act on your environment.

## What loneliness stirs up

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The psychodynamic lens sheds light on what loneliness reactivates: the fatigue of being 'the only one', the reflex of having learned to carry everything alone, sometimes the inherited belief that you can only count on yourself.

These reflexes protected you. Recognizing them means no longer mistaking them for a truth ('I'm made to be alone').

### *Example*

*Used to being 'the strong one everyone leans on', Awa never dared ask for help. She linked the reflex to her history, not to a lack of love around her.*

### **Exercise — What I carry alone**

Write: Since when have I felt lonely? · What I learned to carry alone · What it tried to protect me from.

### **A letter to the part that carries it all**

Write to the part of you that believes it must handle everything alone. Thank it — then tell it it's allowed to lean on others.

→ *My loneliness comes from my history and a system — not a flaw in me.*

## The thoughts that isolate

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CBT spots the thoughts that isolate: 'I'd be a bother', 'no one really gets what I live', 'I have to stay strong'. These distortions push you to withdraw... which deepens loneliness.

By spotting and softening them, you break the loop of isolation.

### *Example*

*Sure she'd 'be a bother', Nia didn't dare text her friends. One simple message was enough: the warm reply disproved her thought.*

### **Log of isolating thoughts**

Each time you withdraw, note: the situation · the thought ('I'm a bother...') · a fairer thought.

### **The small test**

Pick ONE very simple bid for connection (a text, a call) to test the thought 'I'll be a bother'. Note what actually happens.

→ *Withdrawing soothes for a moment but feeds loneliness. One small bond loosens it.*

## Setting down the strong-woman mask

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The humanistic lens invites you to set down the mask of the 'strong woman' who needs no one. Having needs, asking, being vulnerable isn't weakness: it's human — and it's what creates real bonds.

Being good company to yourself — gently — is the foundation of every other bond.

### *Example*

*Instead of enduring her evenings alone, Léa began to inhabit them (a real meal, some care, a book) AND to allow herself to say 'I need company'.*

### **Exercise — Setting down the mask**

1. Where do I play 'the strong one' when I actually need support? 2. One thing I allow myself to ask for this week.

### **Self-compassion**

Write a gentle line to tell yourself on lonely evenings: e.g. 'I deserve tenderness, even my own.'

→ *I don't have to be strong all the time. Asking is also building a bond.*

## Building bonds where you're seen

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The systemic lens reminds us that bonds are woven within a network — and that for many Black women, spaces where you feel truly seen and safe are missing. It's not yours to carry alone: you can seek (or create) those spaces.

Sisterhood, circles of Black women, communities, regular activities: places where you have nothing to prove ease loneliness.

### *Example*

*By joining a circle of Black women, Fatou stopped feeling like 'the only one': her experiences were shared, understood — and the loneliness eased.*

### **Exercise — My spaces**

1. Where do I feel seen, whole, safe? 2. ONE space/community to join. 3. ONE bond to nurture this week.

### **A regular date**

Set up ONE recurring bond ritual (a weekly coffee, a Sunday call). Regularity matters more than intensity.

→ *Bonds are woven — one thread at a time, in spaces where I'm seen.*

## Practical tips & advice

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### Tips & advice

- Join a space (online or in person) of Black women: a talking circle, a group, a community — where you have nothing to prove.
- This week, send ONE simple message to an acquaintance: 'I'd love for us to meet up.'
- Choose ONE regular activity (class, group, sport): regularity creates familiar faces.
- Unfollow accounts that make you feel 'less than'; follow those who look like you and inspire you.
- Dare to name your needs: 'I could use some company this weekend' is not a bother.
- Start small: one bond at a time, not the whole network at once.

# To fill in

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## Log of isolating thoughts

| Day | The situation | The thought | A fairer thought |
|-----|---------------|-------------|------------------|
|     |               |             |                  |
|     |               |             |                  |
|     |               |             |                  |
|     |               |             |                  |
|     |               |             |                  |

## My woven bonds

| Date | The bond I nurtured | How it felt |
|------|---------------------|-------------|
|      |                     |             |
|      |                     |             |
|      |                     |             |
|      |                     |             |
|      |                     |             |

## PLAN

# Your 4-week plan

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**Week 1** — Understand where my loneliness comes from.

**Week 2** — Spot and soften the isolating thoughts.

**Week 3** — Set down the mask, take care of myself.

**Week 4** — Join a space, nurture a bond.

### Your plan in 3 lines

- The space / bond I'm joining:
- What I allow myself to ask for:
- My regular bond ritual:

TO CLOSE

## **You can build bonds where you're seen, whole.**

*You are not the problem. What you live is real — and you can build connection.*

*The loneliness you feel — and being so often ‘the only one’ — is real: this guide never questions it. It is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not therapy. If you are going through a hard time, you are not alone: please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.*